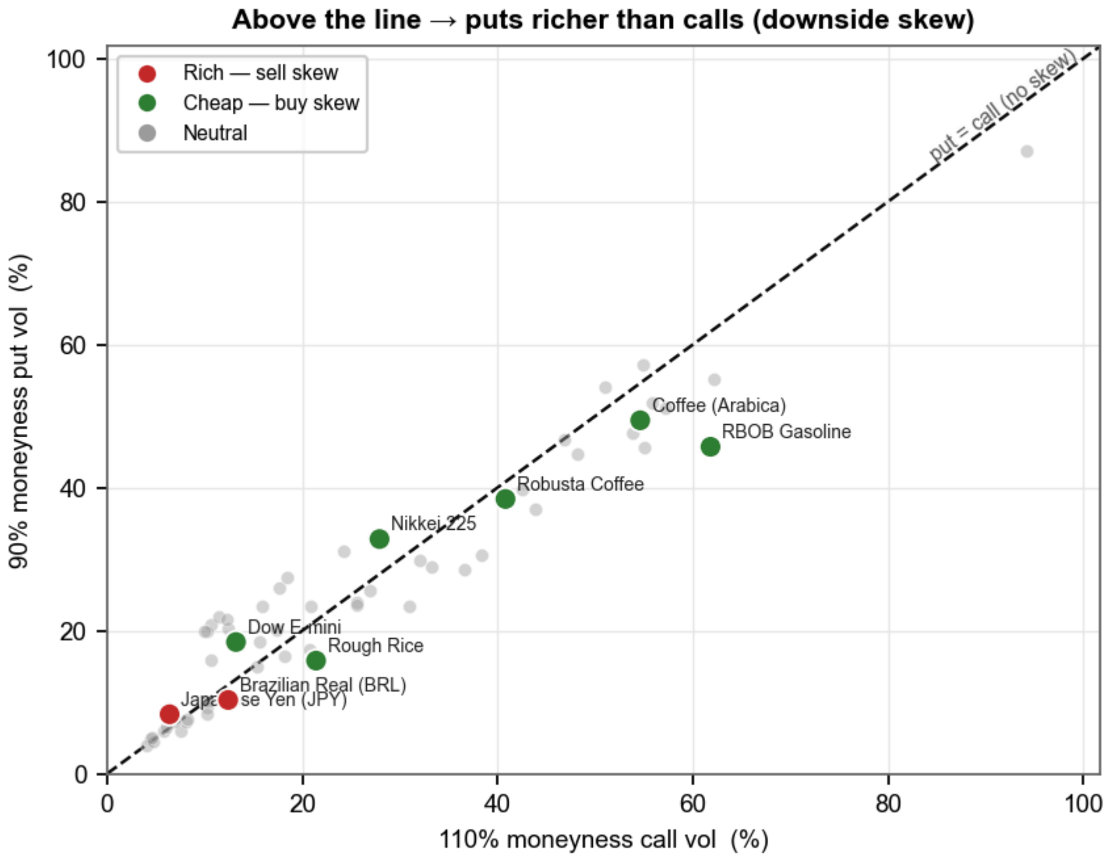
Skew Volatility

Wed 12th August 2026 | XP Inc. Global Macro

Eight markets stand out today. Two carry unusually **rich** put skew, the market paying up for downside protection: **Japanese Yen (JPY) and Brazilian Real (BRL)**. Six look **cheap**, with downside protection under-priced against its own history: **Nikkei 225, Coffee (Arabica), Dow E-mini, Robusta Coffee, RBOB Gasoline and Rough Rice**. They are highlighted purely as markets where the skew currently looks stretched, and may be worth a closer look.

> **How to read this.** Skew = **(90% put − 110% call) / ATM** (FX: 25Δ risk reversal); flagged when more than **1.5σ** from its own one-year norm — puts unusually dear = **rich**, unusually cheap = **cheap**. Full methodology on the closing page.

PUT VS CALL — THE SKEW AT A GLANCE



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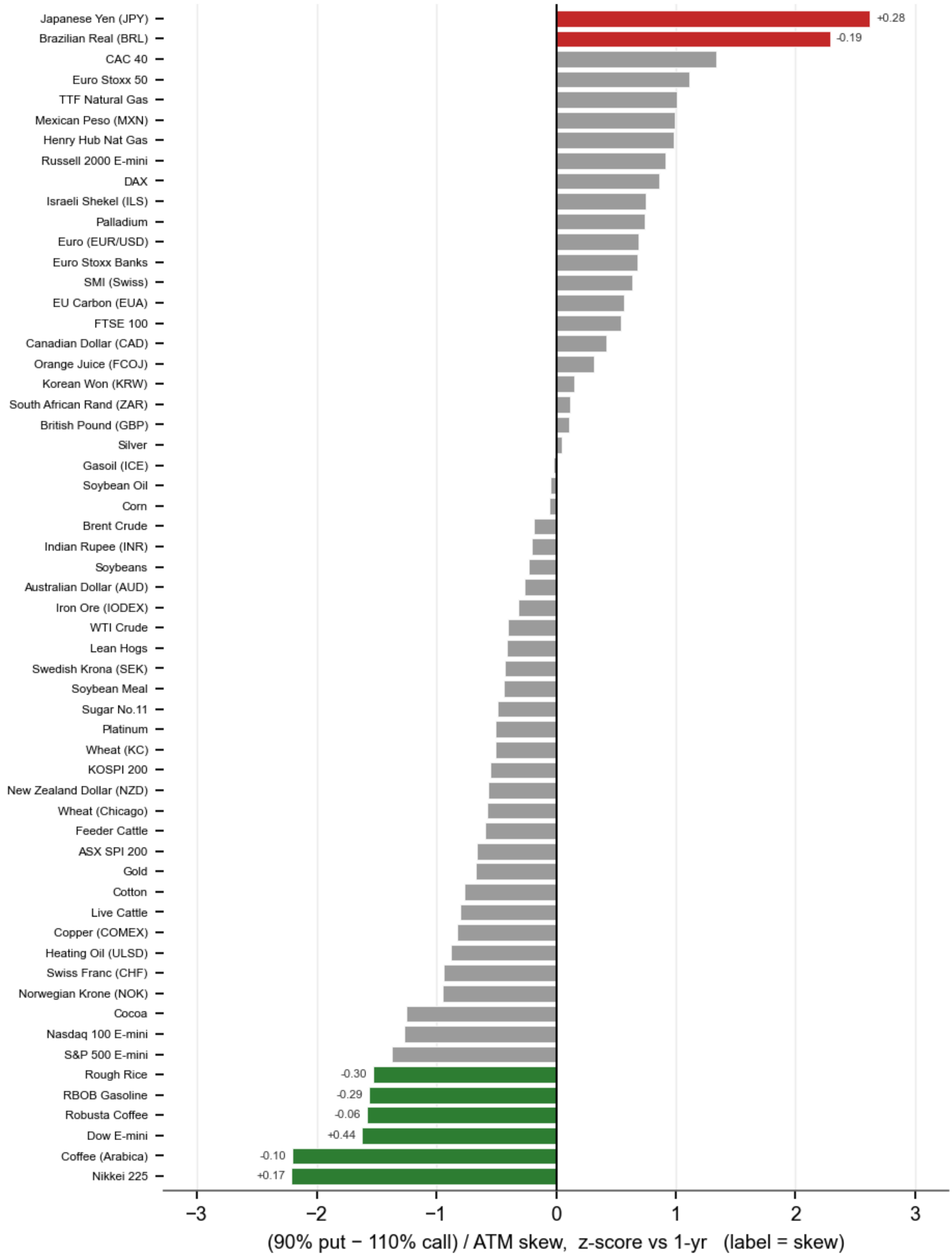
MOST STRETCHED SKEW — RANKED BY Z-SCORE

All markets ranked by spread z-score — flagged in colour



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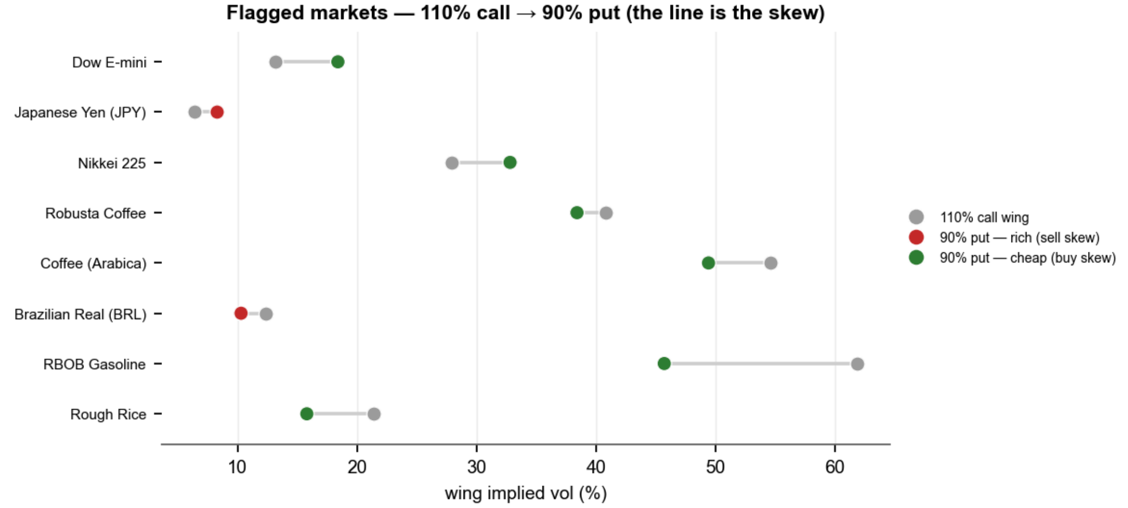
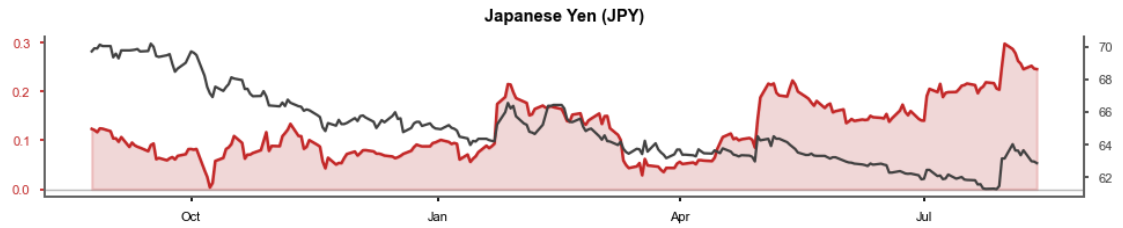
FLAGGED — 110% CALL VS 90% PUT WING

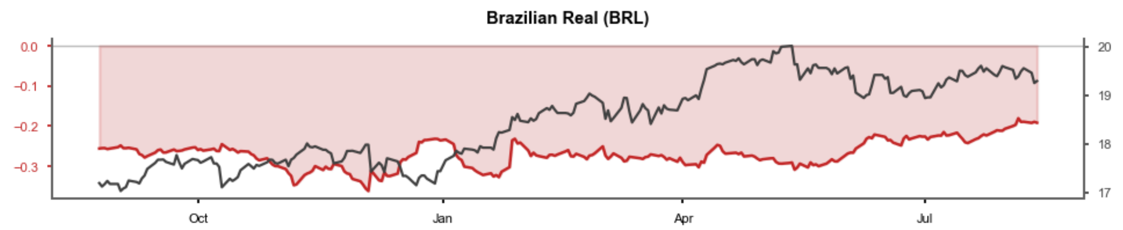


FLAGGED — SKEW VS UNDERLYING (1 YEAR)

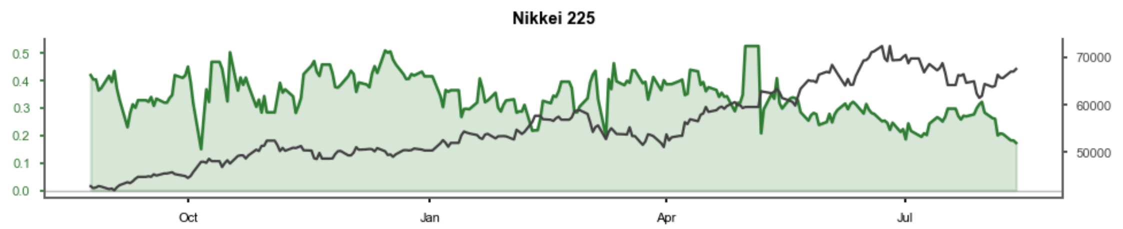
shaded / coloured: (90% put − 110% call) / ATM skew (left axis) · grey: underlying price (right axis)



Skew has stretched to its most put-heavy reading of the past year, with the 90% put wing at **8.3** against **6.4** for the 110% call (ATM **7.0**) — a normalized skew of **+0.28**, the **99th** percentile. Over the past month the puts have added **+1.4** points versus **+0.9** for the calls, all while the underlying is up just **+1%**.



Here the put wing sits at **10.3** against **12.4** for the 110% call (ATM **11.0**), putting normalized skew at **-0.19** — the **98th** percentile and the most put-skewed this market has been over the past year. The move has been gradual, with puts up **+0.8** points over the month against **+0.6** for the calls as the underlying slipped **-1%**.



Puts haven't been this cheap relative to calls since **early October 2025**, when the underlying had rallied **+11%** in a month — today the 90% put is marked at **32.8** against **27.9** for the 110% call (ATM **28.5**), a normalized skew of **+0.17** at the **1st** percentile. This time the picture is different: over the past month the put wing has shed **-2.0** points while the calls are up **+0.7**.

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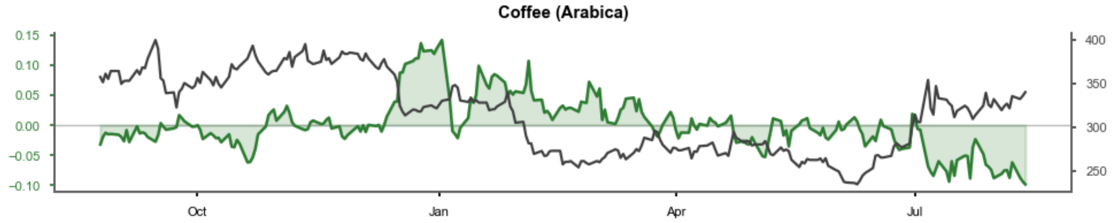
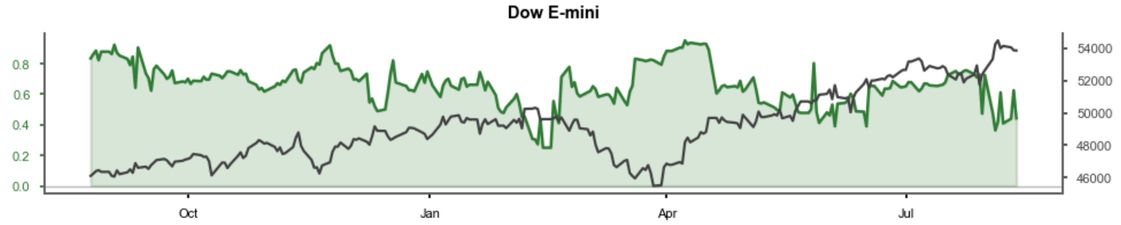
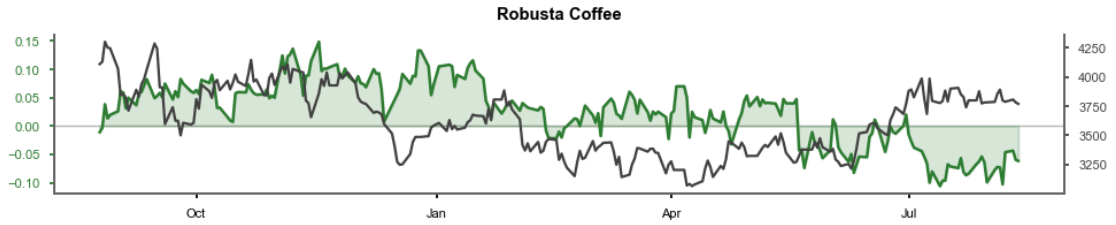


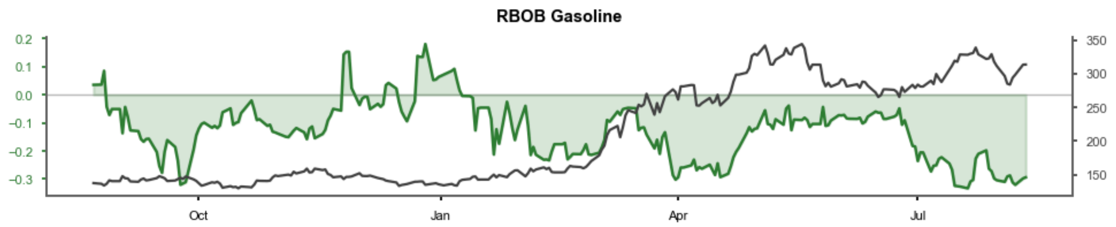
This is the most call-skewed this market has been all year, with the 90% put at **49.4** below the 110% call at **54.6** (ATM **52.9**) for a normalized skew of **-0.10** — the **0th** percentile. Notably, both wings have come in together over the month, puts down **-7.2** points against **-7.5** for the calls, with the underlying up **+4%** along the way.



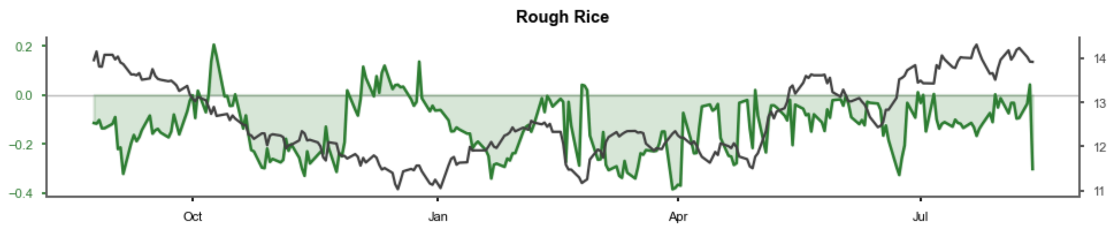
At a normalized skew of **+0.44** — the 90% put marked at **18.4** versus **13.2** for the 110% call (ATM **11.8**) — this sits at just the **6th** percentile of the past year, a level of relative put cheapness last seen in **mid June** when the underlying had climbed **+5%** in a month. The recent driver is clear on the chart: puts have dropped **-4.9** points over the month against only **-1.2** for the calls, with the underlying up **+2%**.



The chart shows skew at the **10th** percentile of its one-year range, with the 90% put at **38.4** against **40.8** for the 110% call (ATM **40.1**) — a normalized reading of **-0.06** last matched in **early July**, when the underlying had run **+12%** in a month. Interestingly, this time it's the calls doing the work, down **-7.5** points over the month against **-5.6** for the puts.



Call skew dominates here, with the 90% put at **45.7** well under the 110% call at **61.8** (ATM **54.6**) for a normalized skew of **-0.29** — the **7th** percentile, a zone last visited in **late March** when the underlying had surged **+53%** in a month. The current backdrop is far tamer, with the underlying up **+3%** over the month as the calls gained **+12.7** points against **+7.3** for the puts.



Worth flagging that puts here are the cheapest relative to calls since **late June**, with the 90% put at **15.8** against **21.4** for the 110% call (ATM **18.6**) — a normalized skew of **-0.30** at the **6th** percentile of the past year. Over the past month the put wing has fallen **-6.1** points against just **-2.7** for the calls, even with the underlying only **+1%** over the same stretch.

FLAGGED SKEW OPPORTUNITIES

Market	Instrument	Signal	90% Put	110% Call	ATM	Skew	z (1y)	%ile
Japanese Yen (JPY) · FX	JYA Curncy	**Rich — sell skew ▼**	8.3	6.4	7.0	+0.28	+2.62	99
Brazilian Real (BRL) · FX	BRA Curncy	**Rich — sell skew ▼**	10.3	12.4	11.0	-0.19	+2.29	98

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Market	Instrument	Signal	90% Put	110% Call	ATM	Skew	z (1y)	%ile
Nikkei 225 · Indices	NKY Index	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	32.8	27.9	28.5	+0.17	-2.21	1
Coffee (Arabica) · Softs	KCA Comdty	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	49.4	54.6	52.9	-0.10	-2.20	0
Dow E-mini † · Indices	DMA Index	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	18.4	13.2	11.8	+0.44	-1.62	6
Robusta Coffee · Softs	DFA Comdty	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	38.4	40.8	40.1	-0.06	-1.58	10
RBOB Gasoline · Energy	XBA Comdty	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	45.7	61.8	54.6	-0.29	-1.56	7
Rough Rice † · Agriculture	RRA Comdty	**Cheap — buy skew ▲**	15.8	21.4	18.6	-0.30	-1.53	6

† our settlement-built wings print a materially different skew from the vendor's surface (gap ≥ 0.10) — **Dow E-mini** -0.18 · **Rough Rice** -0.34. The table shows our numbers, taken from listed settlements.

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DEFINITIONS & METHODOLOGY

Skew — (90% put − 110% call) / ATM: how much more the market pays for downside protection than upside participation; positive = puts the dearer side.

The wings — our own constant-30-day vols at the listed strikes nearest 90% and 110% moneyness, inverted from option settlements (vendor surface as per-date backstop; FX uses its native OTC 25Δ risk reversal — it has no moneyness surface).

z-score & percentile — how stretched today's skew is against its own trailing year; |z| ≥ 1.5 flags a market, the percentile ranks it (100 = most put-skewed of the year).

Rich / cheap — puts unusually dear versus the market's own history read **rich**; unusually cheap read **cheap**.

Reading the panels — shaded / coloured = the skew (left axis); grey = the underlying price (right axis).

Coverage — bonds and STIRs are excluded: at low price vol the 90/110% strikes sit far out-of-the-money where the surface is extrapolated.

Sources & timing. Wing and ATM vols are **our own construction** for 32 of the 58 markets: the settlement prices of the listed OTM put nearest 90% and OTM call nearest 110% moneyness, inverted through Black-76 and interpolated to a constant 30 days, over the same fitted ATM as the Volatility Report. The vendor surface backstops any market or date our build cannot price; FX uses its native OTC 25Δ risk reversal; short-duration bond futures stay on the vendor surface — their ±10% wings sit at strikes no exchange lists, so those published values are model extrapolation rather than market marks. † marks markets where our wings and the vendor's disagree by 0.10+ of skew. Figures are as of the **Wed 12th August 2026** close, pulled 13 Aug 2026, 14:35.

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